

Session 22: The Reunification of Israel

Key Takeaways

- Genesis 2 introduces an Eden ideal of unity when the lone human is divided into two and then united in covenant.
- Reconciliation in the messiah is an act of new creation.
- Ezekiel 37:15-28 is the crescendo of chapters 34-37, recalling the language and themes of the previous units.

Translation and Literary Design of Ezekiel 37:15-28

¹⁵ And the word of Yahweh came again to me, saying:

¹⁶ “And you, Son of a human,
take for yourself **one** **wood-piece** and write on it:

‘For Judah
and for the sons of Israel,
his companions.’

And take **one** **wood-piece** and write on it:

‘For Joseph,
the **wood-piece** of Ephraim,
and all the house of Israel, his companions.’

¹⁷ And make them come near, **one** to **one**, for yourself,
into **one** **wood-piece**,
and they will be one in your hand.

¹⁸ And when the sons of your people speak to you saying,
‘Will you not declare to us what these mean to you?’

¹⁹ say to them,
‘Thus says Yahweh Elohim,
“Look, I will take the **wood-piece** of Joseph,
which is in the hand of Ephraim,
and the tribes of Israel, his companions,
and I will put them with it,
with the **wood-piece** of Judah,
and I will make them into **one** **wood-piece**,

and they will be **one** in my hand.”

20 And the **wood-pieces** on which you write,
they will be in your hand before their eyes.

21 And say to them,

‘Thus says Yahweh Elohim,

“Look, **I will take the sons of Israel from among the nations where they have gone**,
and I will gather them from every side,
and I will bring them into **their own land**;

22 and I will make them **one nation in the land**, on the mountains of Israel;
and **one king** will be king for all of them,
and they will no longer be two nations,
and they will no longer be divided into **two kingdoms**.

23 **And they will no longer be** made **impure**

by their dung-balls,

or by their detestable things,

or by any of their transgressions,

and **I will rescue them from all their dwelling places in which they have sinned**,

and I will **purify** them,

and they will be my people,

and I will be their Elohim.

24 And **my servant David will be king** over them,
and they will all have **one** shepherd,
and they will walk in my decisions,
and they will keep my statutes,
and they will do them,

25 and **they will dwell** on **the land**,
which I gave to **my servant**, **to Jacob**,
on which your fathers **dwelt**,
and **they will dwell** on it,
they and their sons and their sons’ sons, forever;
and **David my servant will be their chief forever**.

26 And I will cut a **covenant of peace** with them,
and it will be a **forever covenant** with them,
and I will place them and make them multiply,

and will place **my sanctuary in their midst forever**,

27 and **my dwelling place** also will be with them,

and I will be their Elohim
and they will be my people,

²⁸ and the nations will know that I am Yahweh who makes Israel holy,
when **my sanctuary is in their midst** forever .””

Ezekiel 37:15-28. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Two Pieces of Wood, Israel’s Reunion, and the New Temple

The two objects are literally called “trees” (Heb. *’ets* / עץ), which could either be a wooden staff/scepter of some kind, or perhaps a writing tablet made of wood (see Block, [The Book of Ezekiel, Chapters 25–48](#)), which could be joined with others into a notebook of sorts.

The sign act is dominated by vocabulary about “one/unity/unified” (Heb. *’ekhad* occurs 11 times in this section) and foretells the reunification of the divided people of Israel, a rift that goes back approximately 400 years by Ezekiel’s day (see [1 Kgs. 12-13](#)). The sign act emphasizes that there is one future hope in one renewed covenant for the one people of God.

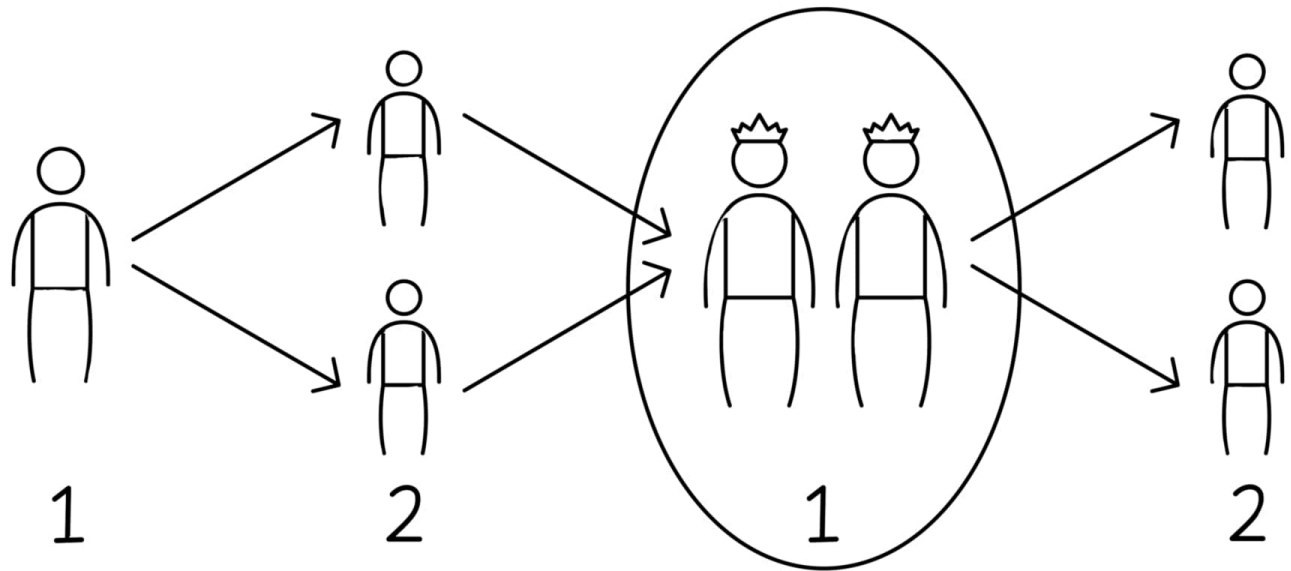
[Ezekiel 37:22-28](#) picks up vocabulary and images from all the oracles of hope in chapters 34-37 and puts them all together in a mosaic.

- 37:21: Regathering the exiles from among the nations ([11:17](#); [20:34](#), [41](#); [28:25](#); [34:13](#))
- 37:22, 24-25: Future messianic king/new David ([34:23-24](#))
- 37:23: Purification from impurity and idolatry ([36:25](#))
- 37:24: Israel’s obedience to the Torah ([36:27](#))
- 37:25: Abundant life in the land promised to the patriarchs ([36:28](#))
- 37:26: Eternal covenant of peace ([34:2](#) covenant of peace, and [16:60](#) eternal covenant)
- 37:28: The nations recognize Yahweh ([36:21-23](#))

The final lines of 37:26-28 point forward to chapters 40-48 with a renewed Israel back in the promised land and Yahweh’s new temple right in the middle.

One Becomes Many Reunited

GEN 2



One Becomes Many Reunited. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Reflection Question

Why is unity such an important topic for the biblical authors?